**Aquifer Open Study Notes**

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# Galatians

## Galatians 1:1

- Paul, an apostle: Apostles were representatives with authority given by a church or council (for example, 2 Corinthians 8:23; Philippians 2:25). However, the Jerusalem church did not appoint Paul as an apostle. Instead, Jesus Christ himself chose Paul, giving him Christ's authority (Acts 9:1–15; 26:12–20; see also Romans 1:5). This authority was equal to that of other apostles.
- Paul said that God the Father gave him his authority as an apostle. This happened because God raised Jesus from the dead. The fact that Jesus rose from death made it possible for Paul to receive his special work from God.

## Galatians 1:1–5

In all his letters, Paul introduces himself and greets the recipients. This greeting stands out because:

1. Paul strongly asserts his authority as an apostle (1:1).
2. Instead of offering thanks, prayer, or praise, he gives a rebuke (1:6–10).

## Galatians 1:1–2.21

Some people were against Paul and questioned whether he was a true apostle. They did not believe he was honest and did not think he had the right to be a leader in the church. So Paul begins his letter by explaining that he really was an apostle with authority from God.

## Galatians 1:2

- all the brothers with me: Paul likely wrote from Antioch of Syria. Antioch was the center of Paul's ministry and the first hub of Gentile Christianity (see Acts 11:20–26). Paul was not alone, although his opponents in Galatia might have suggested that, but he was in fellowship with an important New Testament church.
- Paul probably founded the churches of Galatia during his first missionary journey (Acts 13:4–14:26; see Galatians Book Introduction, "Recipients").

## Galatians 1:3

Grace and peace to you from God: This is a common greeting by Paul (see also study note on 1 Corinthians 1:3). It combines Greek and Hebrew greetings. "Grace" (Greek charis) is similar to "greetings" (Greek chairein). "Peace" reflects Hebrew shalom. Paul included both Jewish and non-Jewish Christians (compare Galatians 3:28). The Galatians risked losing God's grace and peace (3:1–4; 5:1–4).

## Galatians 1:3–5

Paul followed the common style for first-century letters. He included a greeting, wished for well-being, and introduced the main topic, the good news about Jesus.

## Galatians 1:4

- Since Jesus fully rescued us from our sins, we do not need to try to save ourselves.
- Christian faith rescues us from the evil world we live in (see 4:8–12; 5:13–26).

## Galatians 1:4–5

This summary of the good news about Jesus is the basis for the following criticism (1:6–10). It might be a creed or statement of faith that Paul used to remind the Galatians of the message they had accepted before.

## Galatians 1:5

We should thank God alone for salvation because it is his work alone.

## Galatians 1:6

- The Galatians were deserting (or abandoning) God by rejecting the good news about Jesus that Paul shared. Instead, they were depending on the law. God called them to himself through Christ's loving mercy, not through the law (2:16).
- the One who called you: See 1:15; Romans 8:30; 9:24; 11:29.
- a different gospel: Some people taught that non-Jewish Christians had to be circumcised to join God's family. Paul rejected any requirement other than faith in Jesus (see Galatians 5:2–4).

## Galatians 1:6–10

I am amazed: In most of his letters, Paul usually expressed gratitude and prayed for those who received his letters after his greeting (for example, Romans 1:8–10; 1 Corinthians 1:4–5; Philippians 1:3–6; Colossians 1:3–5; 2 Thessalonians 1:3–12). But he had nothing positive to say about the Galatian church.

## Galatians 1:7

- The "different gospel" (1:6) was a distortion and not the true message of salvation. The only way to be

saved is through faith in Christ. Adding any extra requirements changes the message and it is no longer the good news.
- some people are troubling you and trying to distort the gospel of Christ: The Judaizers (a group insisting on Jewish customs) knew they were altering the good news about Jesus to match their beliefs.

## Galatians 1:8–9

- let him be under a curse! (literally Let that person be anathema): The Greek word anathema often translates the Hebrew kherem, which in the Old Testament means something dedicated to God for complete destruction (see Leviticus 27:28–29; compare Romans 9:3; 1 Corinthians 12:3; 16:22). Paul called for God's strongest wrath on those who distort the good news about Jesus (Galatians 1:7).
- even if we or an angel from heaven: No one is allowed to change the good news (compare 2:6–10, 11–14).

## Galatians 1:9

a gospel contrary to the one you received: the gospel (the good news about Jesus) the Galatians had received was exactly what Paul had preached to them (1:8; compare 2 Thessalonians 2:15).

## Galatians 1:10

- The tone and content of this letter show that Paul did not seek to win people's approval. The Judaizers likely criticized Paul for trying to please people by focusing only on faith and grace, not including the law, which they saw as the whole message.
- Being Christ's servant means staying true to Christ, no matter how others react (see Acts 5:29; Ephesians 6:5–6; 1 Thessalonians 2:3–6).

## Galatians 1:11

the gospel I preached: Paul taught that people are made right with God by grace and through faith, not by following the law (see 2:16–17; Romans 10:9–13; Ephesians 2:8–9).

## Galatians 1:11–2.21

The Judaizers (people who insisted on following Jewish customs) came to Galatia. They preached that both faith and circumcision were necessary. They questioned Paul's authority as an apostle and tried to discredit his message. Paul defended his authority by showing that past events proved his message was the true good news.

## Galatians 1:12

- I did not receive it from any man, nor was I taught it: Jewish scholars mainly relied on teachers. The Judaizers claimed Paul received his special mission and message from the other apostles, but then had unfaithfully changed the message.
- I received it by revelation from Jesus Christ: See 1:17; Acts 9:3–15; 26:12–18. Paul's unique experience gave him special authority and insight. However, he learned many things about the life of Jesus from other people (for example, Galatians 1:18; 1 Corinthians 11:23–26; 15:3–11).

## Galatians 1:13–14

To show that his message was not from human reasoning (devised by man, 1:11), Paul explains his life before meeting Jesus. He was a very successful Jew (see Acts 8:1–3; 22:1–5; 26:4–5; Philippians 3:4–7). His opposition to God's church and strict following of Judaism showed his belief in the law before Christ confronted him (Galatians 1:15–16).

## Galatians 1:14

zealous for the traditions of my fathers: Paul was very passionate about following the Jewish religious traditions he learned from his ancestors (see Mark 7:6–13).

## Galatians 1:15–16

- God, who set me apart from my mother's womb: God chose Paul for special work even before he was born. This is like how God chose other leaders (see Jeremiah 1:5; Psalm 139:13–16; Isaiah 49:1–6; Romans 9:10–13).
- called me by His grace: For Paul's conversion story (how he became a follower of Jesus), see Acts 9:1–19; 22:1–21; 26:9–23.
- Paul was called to share the good news about Jesus with non-Jews (Galatians 2:7). He even taught other apostles what this meant (see Galatians 2:11–21).
- to reveal His Son in me: This might refer to Paul's meeting with Christ (Acts 9:1–19; see also 1 Corinthians 9:1; 15:8). In me might also mean an inner revelation (see Galatians 2:20; 4:6–7) and suggests that Paul's changed heart showed Christ to others.

## Galatians 1:16–20

Paul learned directly from the Lord and did not consult with any person, not even the other apostles. Paul was independent from the other apostles but still agreed with them (2:1–10).

## Galatians 1:17

- Paul considered his role as an apostle equal to that of the original disciples (see 1 Corinthians 9:1; 15:5–9; compare Acts 1:22; 10:41).
- Paul's journey to Arabia is not mentioned elsewhere. He likely developed his understanding of the good news about Jesus during that time. Paul was familiar with:
- the Scriptures (see Acts 22:3),
- the beliefs of the first Christians (see Acts 8:1), and
- what others had shared with him since he became a follower of Jesus.

## Galatians 1:18

- Only after three years (or in the third year): This could be three years after Paul became a follower of Jesus or three years after his return from Arabia. This event is likely the visit mentioned in Acts 9:26–30.
- to confer with Cephas (Peter): Peter had something Paul did not—personal experience with Jesus during his time on Earth.
- Paul spent fifteen days with Peter. This was not enough time for Peter to become Paul's teacher, but it gave them enough time to talk carefully about what they were teaching people about Jesus.

## Galatians 1:18–20

Peter and James spent fifteen days discussing Paul's message, which matched theirs. Paul did not get his authority from the Jerusalem church. His role and authority as an apostle was independent of Jerusalem.

## Galatians 1:20

I assure you before God: Paul swears before God to emphasize that his story about his trip to Jerusalem is true.

## Galatians 1:21–22

Paul was not working under the guidance of the apostles in Jerusalem or the churches in Judea.

## Galatians 1:23–24

The church in Jerusalem was very happy when Paul became a follower of Jesus. This change (compare 1:13–14) and his message were both God's work (compare Acts 9:31). The way Paul taught about Jesus matched what the Jerusalem church believed.

## Galatians 2:1

- Counting fourteen years from Paul's conversion (1:15–17), instead of from his previous visit (1:18), fits well with the events in Acts.
- The Galatian Christians knew who Barnabas was. This suggests that Paul and Barnabas first shared the good news about Jesus with them during their first missionary trip together (Acts 13:4–14:26; see Galatians Book Introduction, "Recipients").
- Titus was a non-Jewish believer who worked closely with Paul to help lead and strengthen churches. For more on Titus, see the "Titus" Profile.

## Galatians 2:1–10

When Paul visited Jerusalem for the second time, the other apostles agreed that what he was teaching was correct. According to tradition, Paul was writing about the important meeting of church leaders described in Acts 15:1–41. However, it is more likely that Paul was talking about his earlier visit to Jerusalem (Acts 11:30; 12:25; see Galatians Book Introduction, "Date of Writing").

## Galatians 2:2

- If Paul's visit in 2:1–10 was the same visit described in Acts 11:30, then God might have shown his will through the prophet Agabus's message and the church's decision to send help during a famine (Acts 11:27–29).
- If Paul needed approval from Jerusalem's leaders, he would have met them openly. Their private meeting shows no one thought he needed public approval.
- to those recognized as leaders: Paul does not speak about those leaders as if they were extremely important. He probably wrote this way because false teachers were giving these leaders too much respect and honor.
- Paul shared his message with the apostles in Jerusalem, not for approval, but to ensure agreement, preventing a split between Jewish and non-Jewish groups.
- for fear that I was running or had already run in vain: A division between Jewish and non-Jewish Christians would harm the unity Christ established (Galatians 3:28).

## Galatians 2:3

The apostles in Jerusalem fully agreed with Paul's message. They all believed the same good news: God's grace comes through faith in Christ, not by following the law. The Jerusalem apostles clearly did not believe

that circumcision was necessary for a non-Jew like Titus.

## Galatians 2:4

- Paul called some supposed believers false, saying they were not Christians. They did not understand or truly accept the good news about Jesus, unlike the apostles in Jerusalem (2:3).
- had come in under false pretenses: Paul suggests that a larger group of Jewish "Christians" opposed his preaching (see Acts 15:5) and supported the false teachers who joined the church.
- Requiring non-Jewish Christians to follow Jewish law would trap them in rules and deny the good news of Jesus (see Galatians 3:23–4:11).

## Galatians 2:4–5

The false Christians entered the church in either Jerusalem or Antioch to weaken Paul's message. He taught that non-Jews (Gentiles) do not have to obey Jewish practices like circumcision.

## Galatians 2:5

- We did not give in to them for a moment: Titus was not circumcised (2:3). Paul did not require circumcision for non-Jewish Christians.
- so that the truth of the gospel would remain with you: The false teaching would ruin the the gospel (the good news about Jesus) by adding extra requirements and questioning the effectiveness of the death of Jesus and the grace of God (compare 2:11–21).

## Galatians 2:6

- The apostles in Jerusalem were seen as great leaders because they knew Jesus during his time on Earth. However, this did not give them more authority than Paul. What mattered most was Jesus personally choosing them (see 1 Corinthians 9:1; compare 2 Corinthians 12:11–12).
- God does not show favoritism: The Judaizers (a group insisting on Jewish customs) likely thought the Jerusalem apostles' direct connection to Jesus was an advantage. Paul argues that favoritism is not in God's character (compare Leviticus 19:15–16; Deuteronomy 1:17; 2 Chronicles 19:7; Job 13:10; Psalms 82:1–2; Proverbs 18:5; Malachi 2:8–9).

## Galatians 2:6–10

Paul's message agreed with the Jerusalem apostles, but their approval did not give Paul his authority (1:12, 16–20).

## Galatians 2:7–8

The apostles in Jerusalem noticed that Paul and Peter focused on different groups in their ministry:

- Peter mainly taught Jewish people (Acts 1:1–5:42; 9:1–10:48).
- Paul mainly taught non-Jewish people (Acts 13:1–28:31).

Even though they worked with different groups, they both taught the same good news (gospel) about Jesus.

## Galatians 2:9

- James: To learn more about James, who was the brother of Jesus. See "James, Brother of Jesus" Profile.
- they gave me and Barnabas a right hand of fellowship: This symbolic handshake showed full acceptance of Paul, Barnabas, their work, and their message.

## Galatians 2:10

When Paul talks about helping the poor, this matches the story in Acts 11:30; 12:25. The Christians in Judea experienced many years of severe poverty. Paul wanted the non-Jewish churches to help ease this hardship and create unity with the Jewish church (see Romans 15:25–27; 1 Corinthians 16:1–4; 2 Corinthians 8:1–9:15).

## Galatians 2:11

- When Cephas came to Antioch: Paul confronting Peter in the city of Antioch is not in the book of Acts, but it likely happened after Paul and Barnabas came back from their first journey to tell people about Jesus (Acts 14:26–28). Paul probably wrote this letter soon after. (The apostle Paul often used the name Cephas when writing about Peter in his letters. Cephas is an Aramaic word that means "rock" or "stone." In Greek, this same name is Petros, which we know in English as "Peter.")
- he stood condemned: Peter's actions did not match what he knew—that God accepts non-Jews through faith, not by following the law (see Acts 10–11).
- Paul had to confront Peter directly. Paul wanted to protect the good news from being changed (Galatians 2:21). This meant publicly showing that Peter's public action was wrong (compare 1 Timothy 5:20).

## Galatians 2:11–21

In Antioch, Peter and others went against their own beliefs and changed the good news about Jesus. This event is not mentioned in the book of Acts. Paul cor-

rected Peter, showing that Paul's role as an apostle was independent of Jerusalem and true to the good news about Jesus.

## Galatians 2:12

- Peter ate with the non-Jewish believers because God had shown him it was right (Acts 10:9–16, 34–35).
- James's friends wanted to stop Jewish and non-Jewish believers from eating and meeting together freely. These people insisted that everyone should follow strict Jewish religious customs. They tried to force non-Jewish believers to follow Jewish rules about food and religious practices.
- he used to eat with the Gentiles. But when they arrived, he began to draw back and separate himself: When Peter refused to share meals and the Lord's Supper (see 1 Corinthians 11:20–22, 33–34) with fellow Christians, he created a divide between Jewish and Gentile (non-Jewish) Christians. This suggested that Jewish customs made them more acceptable to God. If not uncorrected, Peter's actions would have weakened the message of salvation by grace through faith.
- for fear of those in the circumcision group: James's friends pressured Peter so much that he became afraid. This was surprising because earlier, when people criticized Peter for the same thing, he had stood up to them bravely and spoke strong words to defend his actions (Acts 11:2–18).

Peter might have had two reasons for his actions. First, he might have worried that his actions would make it harder for Jewish people to accept Jesus. Second, he might have been worried about the safety of Jewish Christians in Judea, who were being treated badly by non-Christian Jews (compare 5:11; 6:12). But even if Peter had good reasons, what he did was still wrong.

## Galatians 2:13

When Peter acted like a hypocrite, he led other Jewish believers to make the same mistake. They started acting as if people needed to follow Jewish customs to be accepted by God, which went against the good news about Jesus.

## Galatians 2:14

- By living like a Gentile (eating with non-Jewish people and not following Jewish food laws), Peter showed that God accepts Gentiles equally with Jews through faith in Christ (see Acts 10:34–43; 11:17–18).
- how can you compel the Gentiles to live like Jews? Both Jews and Gentiles would understand this from Peter's actions.

## Galatians 2:14–21

- When Peter and the other Jewish believers stopped eating with non-Jewish believers, they were sending the wrong message. Their actions suggested that believing in Jesus was not enough and that people also needed to follow Jewish laws to be truly accepted by God. Paul strongly argues against this. He explained that we are made right with God only through his kindness (grace) when we believe in Jesus (Ephesians 2:8–9).
- We cannot tell exactly where Paul's public words to Peter end and his message to the Galatians begins (see study note on Galatians 2:16). When Paul corrected Peter, he was also correcting the Galatians (see 3:1).

## Galatians 2:15

Gentiles were considered "sinners" because they did not have the law and could not obey God's commands. Paul used Jewish thinking categories (compare Matthew 15:21–28; 26:45; Luke 6:32–34; 18:9–14) with strong irony, emphasizing that everyone is sinful (Galatians 2:16; Romans 3:23).

## Galatians 2:16

Both Jews and non-Jews are sinners. The good news requires everyone to admit their sins (see Romans 2:1–5; 3:1–20) and seek God's grace (Romans 3:21–26). Peter later showed he agreed with this message (Acts 15:7–11).

## Galatians 2:17–21

Some false teachers were spreading false ideas about Paul's good news. They likely argued that if people did not have to follow the Jewish laws, they would just do whatever sinful things they wanted. Jesus would then be seen as leading people into sin (2:17). Paul explains how this is not true. Those who trust in Jesus receive strength from the Holy Spirit to live holy lives that honor God (see 5:13–26).

## Galatians 2:18

- I prove myself to be a lawbreaker: Abandoning faith and returning to the law places a person under the law's authority, where everyone faces God's judgment (Romans 3:10–12, 23–24; see Hebrews 6:1–8). This act is a serious sin against Christ (Galatians

5:2–4; compare Hebrews 6:4–6). See also study note on 2:19.
- If I rebuild: This refers to insisting on following Jewish laws about food and circumcision (Galatians 2:11–13).
- When Jesus died on the cross, he ended the old system of religious laws that separated Jewish and non-Jewish people from each other and from God (Ephesians 2:14–16). His death created a new way for all people to come to God through faith.

## Galatians 2:19

- For through the law: Trying to please God by following the law always leads to sin (5:2–4; see Rom 7:5, 8–11). Living by the Spirit leads away from sin (Galatians 5:16, 22–24).
- I died to the law: "Dying to the law" means stopping the attempt to meet all its demands. Those who trust in Christ share in his death (2:20). They are no longer judged by the law (see Romans 6:2, 10–11; 7:2–6) and do not see the law as a way to be saved. Instead, Christians live for God in a new relationship with him through Christ (Galatians 3:23–4:11; see Romans 6:10–11; 14:7–8; 2 Corinthians 5:15).

## Galatians 2:20

- Paul's good news about Jesus (that we do not need to follow Jewish laws to be saved) does not mean people will just do whatever wrong things they want (2:17). This is because lawlessness (ignoring or disobeying God's commands) is a response of those who are not redeemed. A redeemed Christian has been crucified with Christ. See also Colossians 2:11–14, 20–23. A Christian has left behind the old self, which tried to earn merit by following the law (compare Romans 7:4–6).
- I no longer live, but Christ lives in me: Christians have experienced Christ's death and resurrection (Romans 6:1–14). They have new hearts (see Jeremiah 31:31–34; 32:38–41; Ezekiel 11:19–20; 36:24–31). These new hearts come through the Spirit's power within them (see Romans 8:9–11; Ephesians 3:16–19; Colossians 1:27; 3:1–17).
- The life I live in the body: Christianity does not say the body is evil or that we must leave this world to have fellowship with God. Instead, by trusting in the Son of God, we fulfill God's purposes for our lives.
- who loved me and gave Himself up for me: Christ's self-giving love makes new life possible (Galatians 1:4; Romans 8:32–39; 2 Thessalonians 2:16–17).

## Galatians 2:21

Paul's opponents in Galatia might have argued that his message made God's grace to Israel meaningless because it was connected to the law (see Romans 3:12, 31). However, it was actually Paul's opponents who made God's grace meaningless by denying the need for Christ's death.

## Galatians 3:1

- O foolish Galatians! Their foolishness was both intellectual and spiritual (compare Luke 24:25; see 1 Samuel 25:1–38). They stopped trusting in Christ and trusted in the law (Galatians 1:6).
- The Galatians were misled by the teachers' persuasive arguments (compare Genesis 3:1–7). It was not actual witchcraft, but convincing words.
- Before your very eyes Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed as crucified: When Paul told people about Jesus, he clearly explained how Jesus died and why his death was so important for everyone (see Romans 10:14–17). Paul helped people understand what the death of Jesus means for them.

## Galatians 3:1–9

Paul compares the Galatians' spiritual experience (see 3:1–5) with Abraham's (3:6–9). He shows that both were made right with God through faith, not by following the law (Ephesians 2:8–9).

## Galatians 3:1–5.12

Paul now defends the truth of his message that a right relationship with God comes by faith in Christ alone. He argues against the idea that non-Jewish people must follow the law to be accepted by God.

## Galatians 3:2

The Galatians, like all Christians, received the Spirit by faith in Christ, not by obeying the law of Moses (see Acts 2:38–39; Romans 8:9–11; 2 Corinthians 1:22; Ephesians 1:11–14; compare Acts 10:44–48; 11:15–18). God accepted the Galatians because they believed the good news about Jesus (compare Romans 10:14–17). This made their return to the law unreasonable (Galatians 3:3–4).

## Galatians 3:3

are you now finishing in the flesh: Paul used clever word play to make an important point. The Galatians were trying to become perfect by human effort by following the law about circumcising the flesh of the male foreskin.

### Galatians 3:4

Have you suffered so much for nothing? This might mean suffering, but the Galatian church's history does not suggest that. Paul likely referred to the spiritual experiences the Galatians had through the Holy Spirit (Galatians 3:3, 5). Depending on the law of Moses for a right relationship with God makes the Spirit's work seem meaningless.

### Galatians 3:5

work miracles: See 1 Corinthians 12:4–11. The Holy Spirit is with believers and in the church because they have faith in the good news about Jesus.

### Galatians 3:6

This quote is from Genesis 15:6, where God made his covenant (special agreement) with Abraham (see Genesis 15:1–21; 17:1–27). This statement is essential to explain God's relationship with people (see Habakkuk 2:4; Romans 4:1–8, 17–22).

### Galatians 3:6–9

Abraham's story shows that faith has always been the basis for a relationship with God and for receiving God's promises.

### Galatians 3:7

Non-Jewish believers in Jesus are truly part of Abraham's family. They become part of Abraham's family not by following the laws of Moses, but by trusting in God just as Abraham did (see Romans 4:9–17, 23–25; compare Matthew 12:48–50).

### Galatians 3:8

The Scripture foresaw that God would justify the Gentiles by faith: By faith, Abraham expected the coming Messiah (see John 8:56). He received the message that "all the families of the earth will be blessed through you" (Genesis 12:3; 18:18; 22:18). God would accept all nations through Abraham's descendant, the Messiah (God's chosen one), in the same way God accepted Abraham—by faith.

### Galatians 3:10

Paul here quotes Deuteronomy 27:26. This verse explains the curse Israel would experience if they did not follow all of God's commands in their covenant with him (see Deuteronomy 27:9–26; compare Deuteronomy 28:15–68; 31:26; Joshua 1:8; Malachi 2:2; see also Genesis 3:14–19; 4:10–12). Sinful humans cannot fully obey God's will (see Romans 3:9–20).

### Galatians 3:10–12

The Galatians thought they needed to be circumcised to please God. By doing this, they were trying to follow all of God's laws to be accepted by him. Those who seek to be right with God through the law are under a curse. They cannot follow the entire law, so they cannot receive blessings from it.

### Galatians 3:11

- Scripture makes it clear, even if the Galatians or false teachers did not understand, that circumcision is not required for non-Jewish believers.
- "The righteous will live by faith": Paul quotes Habakkuk 2:4, in which the prophet waits in faith for God's promise to come true.

### Galatians 3:12

The law itself is not opposed to faith (see 3:19–25; Romans 7:7–13), but trying to be righteous by following the law opposes righteousness by faith in Christ. Paul quotes Leviticus 18:5 to show that life under the law of Moses requires obedience rather than belief. It is impossible to be accepted by God by trying to obey the law of Moses perfectly (Galatians 3:10–11).

### Galatians 3:13

- redeemed us: Christ freed his people by paying the price for them (see 4:4–5; 1 Peter 1:18–20).
- "Cursed is everyone who is hung on a tree": Paul quotes Deuteronomy 21:23, in which criminals who were killed and had their bodies displayed in public were considered to be under God's curse (see study note on Deuteronomy 21:22). When Jesus was nailed to the cross, he took on God's curse that should have fallen on all sinners (compare 2 Corinthians 5:21).

### Galatians 3:13–14

Unlike those who rely on the law (see 3:10–12), people who have faith in Christ receive God's life and blessings freely.

### Galatians 3:14

Jesus Christ has given the Gentiles (non-Jewish people) the same blessing promised to Abraham, as described in 3:6–13. Paul says this blessing is receiving the promised Holy Spirit (3:2–6; see also Romans 8:1–17, 23; Ephesians 1:13–14).

### Galatians 3:15

When a person dies, their written instructions about who should receive their property (called a will) can-

not be changed. These instructions must be followed exactly as they were written.

## Galatians 3:15–18

Jesus, not the law, has fulfilled the promise and agreement (covenant) made with Abraham.

## Galatians 3:16

The promises to Abraham were mainly received by him and his child (literally his seed). This "seed" was the promised Messiah (God's chosen one), who is Abraham's ultimate descendant. The word "seed" can mean one descendant or many (see Genesis 12:7; 13:15). Although the promise can refer to many descendants (see Galatians 3:29; Genesis 13:15–16; 15:5–6; 17:7–8), it specifically points to one descendant, Christ, who fully fulfilled the promise. The heirs of the promise are not Jacob's physical children but the spiritual children of Christ, by the Spirit through faith.

## Galatians 3:17

- Just as human covenants cannot be canceled (3:15), the terms of God's covenant with Abraham were not changed when God gave Moses the law.
- 430 years: See study note on Exodus 12:40.

## Galatians 3:18

The inheritance cannot come from obeying the law, because that would cancel God's promise to Abraham (see 4:1–7). This promise was accepted by faith before God gave the law to Moses.

## Galatians 3:19

- If people do not receive God's inheritance through the law, why was the law given to Moses? It was to show people their sins and make it clear that sinful actions are wrongs done against God. People cannot rely on their own goodness to save them. Instead, they must trust in God (see Romans 3:19–20; 4:15; 5:20; 7:7–13).
- until the arrival of the seed to whom the promise referred: See Galatians 3:16. While the promise is permanent, the law of Moses was temporary. With Christ's coming, the law was fulfilled (see Matthew 5:17–20; compare Matthew 3:13–15; John 19:30). God's acceptance is based entirely on faith in Christ.
- through angels: Deuteronomy 33:2 in the Greek version (the Septuagint) describes the Lord's coming from Sinai "with myriads of holy ones, angels with him at his right hand." See also Psalm 68:17; Acts 7:38, 53; Hebrews 2:2.
- By a mediator: The mediator was Moses (see Exodus 20:19; Deuteronomy 5:24–27). As a mediator, Moses spoke to God for the people and spoke to the people for God.

## Galatians 3:19–22

Paul's argument might make those hearing his message think the law of Moses has no purpose. However, Paul emphasizes the law's true purpose in order to correct false teaching about the law.

## Galatians 3:20

- The law of Moses was given through angels and a mediator (Moses). The law required agreement between God and the people. The law was conditional, with blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience. In contrast, God gave his promise directly to Abraham without a mediator. It was God's promise alone, and God did not require anything in return.
- but God is one: Paul used the basic Jewish creed (see Deuteronomy 6:4) to persuade non-Jewish Christians not to convert to Judaism.

## Galatians 3:21

There is no conflict of purpose between law and promise or between law and faith. The law works with the promise to help people believe in Jesus. The purpose of the law is to show that people are trapped by their sins (3:19, 22). It is also meant to help people not sin (3:23–25).

In Galatia, the Judaizers tried to convince non-Jewish Christians that the law could do something it was never meant to do. The law was never meant to give new life and make people right with God. God does these things based on faith in his promise, which was fulfilled in Jesus Christ (see 3:22).

## Galatians 3:21–25

See Romans 7:7–13.

## Galatians 3:22

all things confined by sin. See Romans 3:9; 7:1–13; 11:32. Following the law of Moses cannot save us. Only believing in Jesus Christ can free us from sin.

## Galatians 3:23

Because sin had imprisoned us (3:22), the law of Moses acted as a guard, keeping God's people safe (held in custody) until faith in Jesus was revealed. It clearly showed God's requirements and emphasized the need

for a Savior. The law also kept sin under control by clearly showing its consequences.

### Galatians 3:23–29

Paul compares two different times: how God's people lived when they were under the law before Jesus came, and how they live now that they belong to Christ and follow him.

### Galatians 3:24

The law is like a child's guardian. (The Greek word is paidagōgos, meaning "tutor.") In Greco-Roman culture, a guardian was a loyal servant who trained and protected the heir until adulthood.

### Galatians 3:25

- Now that faith has come: Righteousness by faith was always in effect (see 3:6–9), but now, through Jesus Christ, the object of that faith and how people can receive it are clear.
- we are no longer under a guardian: In Greco-Roman culture, a child who reached adulthood was no longer under a guardian's control and could govern themselves. Similarly, those who mature through faith in Christ are free from the law's guardianship. They follow Christ directly as he guides them through his word and Spirit.

### Galatians 3:26

Those who are God's children through faith in Jesus Christ (see also 4:4–7; John 1:12; Romans 9:8) have come of age as heirs to his promises (see Galatians 3:24–25, 29). They have received a part of that inheritance (3:14; Ephesians 1:14). The Galatians acted unwisely by trying to gain access to God through circumcision (Galatians 3:1). As God's children by faith, they already had the best possible access to him.

### Galatians 3:26–29

Because of Christ, our condition under faith is different from our condition under the law (3:23–24).

### Galatians 3:27

- For all of you who were baptized into Christ: See Romans 6:3–4. Baptism symbolizes the death (or end) of an old life and the birth (or beginning) of a new one. In this new life, the law's curse no longer affects us (compare Romans 7:1–6).
- clothed yourselves with Christ: Christ covers us and gives us a new identity. Compare Colossians 3:12; 1 Thessalonians 5:8.

### Galatians 3:28

- Now, everyone comes to Jesus and receives God's promises in the same way (see 1 Corinthians 12:12–13; Ephesians 2:14; Colossians 3:11).
- male nor female: Refer to Genesis 1:27.
- you are all one: Believers form one community, the body of Christ (see Romans 12:4–5; 1 Corinthians 12:27; Ephesians 2:15–16, 19–22).
- in Christ Jesus: See Colossians 2:6–3:11.

### Galatians 3:29

Jesus is the ideal descendant of Abraham (3:16). So, those united with Jesus are also Abraham's children and inherit all his promises (3:27–28).

### Galatians 4:1–3

A child who inherits an estate might get a large fortune. However, before reaching adulthood, the child must follow the rules of guardians and trustees until the time the father decides. In the same way, before Jesus came, God's people were under the guidance of the law of Moses (see 3:23–24).

### Galatians 4:1–7

Paul argues that the purpose of the law of Moses for God's children was fulfilled when Jesus came, so we are no longer bound by it.

### Galatians 4:3

- Before Christ came, God's people were like young heirs to a large estate (4:1–2). They would inherit a great fortune (see 4:5), but they were still under their guardian's care (3:23–25).
- The basic spiritual principles of this world likely refer to the laws that govern the world without Jesus. These principles were fully expressed in the law of Moses (3:23–24; compare 4:5).

### Galatians 4:4–5

- God chose the perfect time in history for Jesus to come (see Luke 4:18–19; Ephesians 4:8–10).
- Jesus was fully human, born of a woman, and required to follow the law of Moses. Jesus fulfilled the law (see Matthew 3:13–15; 5:17) so that God's children now have freedom and are no longer enslaved by it.
- to redeem those: By fulfilling the law and taking on its curse, Jesus freed us from its demands (Galatians 3:13; see also Romans 3:24; Colossians 1:13–14).
- that we might receive our adoption as sons: See also Romans 8:15–17.

## Galatians 4:6

- The Holy Spirit works in our hearts to give us confidence that we are God's children (see Romans 8:16; Ephesians 1:13–14).
- Those with the Spirit of God's Son can call God "Father," just like Jesus did (Mark 14:36; compare Matthew 6:9).

## Galatians 4:8

Before they became Christians, the non-Jewish Galatians worshiped false gods. They worshiped natural things like the sun, moon, and seasons (see Romans 1:25). They lived like slaves to these false gods, constantly afraid they would make them angry (1 Corinthians 8:5–6).

## Galatians 4:8–11

Paul reminds the Galatians of their past pagan beliefs. He argues that following circumcision and the law is like returning to the same kind of slavery they experienced before they knew God.

## Galatians 4:9

- Now that you know God: Christians have a relationship with God like a child with a parent, not like a slave with a master (4:5–7).
- how is it that you are turning back? Paul was confused that Christians would want to return to their old life of spiritual slavery (4:19–20).
- are known by God: God is the one who saves and has taken the initiative in understanding their souls and forgiving them freely (Psalm 139:1–6, 23–24; Luke 2:34–35; Hebrews 4:12).
- By turning back to circumcision (as a way of being accepted by God), the Galatians would be returning to the same useless spiritual principles they knew when they worshiped false gods. Both ways of living required people to work hard to please a demanding master who was never satisfied.

## Galatians 4:10–11

Circumcision was just one way the Galatians tried to follow the law of Moses. They also started celebrating Jewish festivals. They believed this would make them more acceptable to God. To Paul, this showed they misunderstood or rejected the good news of God's grace through Jesus Christ.

## Galatians 4:11

I fear for you: The Galatians were in danger of turning away from Christ by depending on the law. If they did, Paul's efforts would have been wasted. The good news would not benefit them (compare Hebrews 6:4–6; 2 Peter 2:20–22). See Acts 13:44–14:24 for a description of Paul's work for the Christians in that region.

## Galatians 4:12

- become like me: Paul was a devoted Jew. He stopped trying to earn righteousness and accepted God's free grace in Jesus Christ. Now, Paul asks these Gentiles to follow his example instead of adopting the Jewish practices he left behind. Paul's advice throughout the rest of the letter (4:12–6:10) comes from this single command.
- You have done me no wrong: Similarly, the Galatians should not mistreat Paul now but should continue to warmly accept his ministry and message.

## Galatians 4:12–20

After explaining what the Bible teaches, Paul takes a more personal approach. He reminds the Galatians of their close relationship with him.

## Galatians 4:13–14

- because of an illness: Paul might have had a long-term health issue, but we do not know what it was (see 2 Corinthians 12:7). Paul's condition was serious and seemed to cause problems or even upset the new church in Galatia. People often saw physical problems as a sign of God's judgment (see John 9:1–2; Acts 28:4). The Galatians looked beyond Paul's physical state and accepted him as God's messenger (literally angel; Greek angelos).
- as if I were Christ Jesus Himself: See Luke 10:16.

## Galatians 4:15

- The Galatians were happy and thankful when Paul shared the good news about Jesus with them.
- you would have torn out your eyes and given them to me: Some think this means Paul had eye problems, but he might have used eyes as a symbol for something valuable (see Deuteronomy 32:10; Psalm 17:8; Matthew 18:9). The Galatians were thankful for Pual's message of good news. So, the Galatians would have given Paul their most valuable possession.

## Galatians 4:16

At first, the Galatians gladly accepted Paul and his message when they became Christians. But now they were unsure about Paul and possibly even rejected him.

## Galatians 4:17

- Those people are zealous for you: The Greek word here can mean have a positive meaning, like "eagerness," or a negative meaning, like "jealousy" and "envy."
- they want to isolate you from us: The Judaizers (Jewish Christians insisting on following Jewish laws) might have been so eager because they envied the Galatians' devotion to Paul and instead wanted the Galatians to be devoted to them (compare 2 Corinthians; see also Luke 11:46–52). Another possibility is that the Judaizers wanted the Galatians to depend on them as interpreters of the law of Moses.

## Galatians 4:18

It was good for the Galatians to continue eagerly embracing Paul and his message, even when he was not there with them.

Some English Bibles translate like this: If someone is eager to do good things for you, that's all right; but let them do it all the time, not just when I'm with you (New Living Translation). In this case, Paul might be saying that it was okay for others to seek the Galatians' loyalty, but those teachers were not truly trying to help them.

## Galatians 4:19

- The Galatians were like Paul's spiritual children (see 1 Corinthians 4:14–15; Philemon 1:10). Bringing them to Christ was like giving birth to children and experiencing labor pains. It was difficult but rewarding. Now, Paul felt his work was not finished.
- until Christ is formed in you: Paul uses the picture of giving birth to explain something important. If the Galatians continued to trust in Christ as Paul had taught them, Christ's image would grow in them (they would become more and more like Jesus in how they lived and acted). But if they chose to follow the law instead, this new life would die before it could develop. Paul says he must keep working hard, like a midwife who helps with childbirth, to make sure this does not happen.

## Galatians 4:20

If Paul had been there in person, he could have understood his listeners better and adjusted his message to fit their spiritual and emotional needs. From a distance, he was not sure if his tone would be effective.

## Galatians 4:21

Do you not understand what the law actually says?: The Galatians tried to achieve righteousness through the law, but they did not truly understand its meaning (see Luke 24:25–27; 1 Timothy 1:7).

## Galatians 4:21–31

- Paul now returns to using Scripture to support his argument. He tells the story of two of Abraham's wives, Hagar and Sarah, and their children. He uses this story to show the difference between two types of people: those who are like slaves because they try to follow all the laws, and those who are free because they belong to Christ.
- Paul uses a special way of explaining Bible stories (called allegory) that Jewish teachers used in those days (see study note on 4:24). Paul was trained as a rabbi (see Acts 22:3) and could effectively debate the Judaizers using their own methods.

## Galatians 4:22–23

Ishmael was the son of the slave woman, Hagar. She was Sarah's servant (see Genesis 16:15). Sarah gave Hagar to Abraham, trying to get the heir God promised through human efforts (see Genesis 16:1–4). Isaac, Sarah's son, was born to the free woman (see Genesis 21:2–3). God did something miraculous to help Sarah have this baby. This fulfilled God's promise (see Genesis 17:15–21).

## Galatians 4:24

- serve as illustrations (literally are being allegorized): In allegorical writing, every character and event symbolizes a deeper meaning. Allegorical interpretations often ignore the text's historical meaning and create imaginative meanings. Here, however, Paul understood the story in its historical context and saw it as history. But he interpreted the story's characters as symbols of the current situation. Paul's opponents were also using allegorical methods, so Paul countered their flawed allegory with true allegory (see 1 Corinthians 9:22).
- two covenants: The old covenant (God's special agreement with his people) was formed through Moses. The new covenant came through Jesus Christ.
- Mount Sinai... This is Hagar: Just as Hagar was a slave woman symbolizing human effort, Mount Sinai brought slavery to following the law.

## Galatians 4:24–25

Paul connects Abraham's effort to fulfill God's promises with the attempts in Galatia and other places to achieve salvation by following the law (4:23). Hagar, as a slave woman, represents Israel's bondage under the law. This contrasts with the freedom of those who have faith in Jesus Christ (4:26–27).

## Galatians 4:25

- Both Hagar and Mount Sinai were symbols of Jerusalem. They represented Judaism during Paul's time. Judaism continued to trust in the law and in being Abraham's descendants for their status before God (see John 8:31–59). They rejected Jesus as Messiah and remained bound to the law (Galatians 3:23–24; 4:1–3).
- Mount Sinai in Arabia: Traditionally, Mount Sinai is located in the Sinai Peninsula in Egypt. However, some suggest that in Arabia means Mount Sinai was in Midian, where Moses once lived (see Exodus 3:1).

## Galatians 4:26

- Hagar represents slavery to human effort based on Mount Sinai (4:24–25). In contrast, Sarah represents freedom in the heavenly Jerusalem, God's ideal city. Abraham's true children by faith now live under God's rule in Jesus Christ (3:29).
- she is our mother: Sarah's son, Isaac, was freely given all of God's promises apart from the law of Moses. Similarly, Jews and Gentiles who live by faith in Jesus are Sarah's true children. They receive God's promises to Abraham freely apart from the law (3:26–29; 4:4–7).

## Galatians 4:27

The quoted passage, Isaiah 54:1, promised Israel they would thrive after the exile to Babylon. Those who have faith in Jesus Christ are Sarah's children (Galatians 4:26). This fulfills the promise that Sarah, who was childless, would have more children than Hagar, the slave woman. To the Judaizers (those who insisted on following Jewish law), people not following the law might seem desolate (spiritually barren or unfruitful), but through faith, they become abundantly fruitful as the bride of Christ (2 Corinthians 11:2; Ephesians 5:31–33).

## Galatians 4:28–31

Paul uses the story of Hagar and Sarah in 4:21–27 to explain the situation in Galatia. Isaac represents those born through God's promise (see 3:8) by the Spirit's power (3:2–5; see also Ephesians 1:13–14). These people trust in God for salvation through Christ by faith. Ishmael represents those who think following the law of Moses will make them acceptable to God (Galatians 3:10–11). This idea would have surprised the Judaizers, who believed they were Abraham's true children because they followed the law of Moses.

## Galatians 4:29

Isaac was the promised child. During his weaning celebration, Ishmael treated Isaac badly (see Genesis 21:9). Similarly, in Galatia, people who insisted on following the law were treating badly those who trusted in God's promise, the message of God's grace through faith in Jesus Christ alone (compare Acts 13:50–51; 14:1–7).

## Galatians 4:30–31

Sarah's demand about Ishmael in Genesis 21:10 becomes a guideline (see Genesis 21:12) for dealing with the current son of the slave woman (anyone who refuses to abandon slavery to the law). God does not let those who try to be righteous through their own efforts share in his inheritance (see Romans 9:30–33). Those who come to God through Jesus Christ alone, by faith and not by following the law, are children of the free woman who inherit God's blessings.

## Galatians 5:1

- Paul clearly explains his message to the Galatians. He criticizes their unwise behavior and offers a better choice. That choice is freedom.
- Christ has set us free: Christians are free to live by faith in Christ alone (see Romans 8).
- do not be encumbered once more (literally do not take on a yoke): A yoke is a heavy wooden bar that joins two farm animals together, like oxen, so they can pull heavy loads. In the Jewish tradition, people used the word "yoke" to talk about following religious laws. It was a duty and honor to "take the yoke of the law." God's children in Jesus Christ are not meant to carry this heavy burden (see Luke 11:46; Acts 15:10). Instead, they follow the gentle guidance of Jesus, which brings freedom instead of heavy demands (Matthew 11:28–30).

## Galatians 5:2

Paul reminded the Galatians who it was that was speaking to them. He was the apostle of Jesus Christ who represented the Lord to non-Jewish people and first preached the good news to them.

## Galatians 5:2–6

The Judaizers were a group who believed in following the law of Moses. They taught that following the law would earn God's favor (compare Acts 15:1). However, this approach actually leads to separation from God. True righteousness comes to those who live in Jesus Christ by the power of the Holy Spirit.

## Galatians 5:3

People who try to be righteous by obeying the law must obey every one of its rules without exception (see 2:15–16; compare James 2:10).

## Galatians 5:4

People who believe circumcision is needed for salvation depend on the law and themselves, not on Jesus Christ. These people are separated from Jesus and are outside of his grace (see Romans 5:2). They are under the law's judgment. They have lost the benefits of God's grace (see Galatians 1:6; 1 Peter 5:12).

## Galatians 5:5

- Instead of living by faith in the law, we can live by completely trusting in the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit helps us become more like what God wants us to be.
- eagerly await through the Spirit the hope of righteousness: We receive God's righteousness at our salvation (see Romans 5:9–11; 10:10). We receive it in an ongoing way as God's Spirit helps us become more like Jesus (Romans 8:1–14). We receive it fully when Jesus returns and raises us to new life (see Romans 8:18–30). God's power provides righteousness, and he fulfilles his promise (Galatians 3:14, 22).

## Galatians 5:6

Faith in Jesus Christ gives us all of God's favor and grace, so we cannot gain more through our own efforts. We show our faith by loving others (see Romans 13:10; 14:17–19; 2 Corinthians 8:8–13).

## Galatians 5:7

Living by faith is like running a race (see 1 Corinthians 9:24–27; Philippians 3:13–14; 2 Timothy 4:7–8). For the Galatians, the law became an obstacle instead of a support in this race (see Luke 11:52).

## Galatians 5:8

The Galatians believed following the law would make God happy, but God did not want them to be bound by it. God wanted them to be free.

## Galatians 5:9

This verse was a common saying (literally A little yeast [or leaven] makes the whole loaf rise; see Matthew 13:33; 16:6, 11–12; 1 Corinthians 5:6–7). Relying a little on the law for God's acceptance can lead to forgetting that Jesus Christ saves by his work alone.

## Galatians 5:10

whoever he may be: Paul might not have known who the false teachers' were, or he might have thought their qualifications did not matter (compare 2:6).

troubling you: The false teaching distorted the good news, so Paul wrote to clarify their understanding.

## Galatians 5:11

- If I am still preaching: This likely refers to Paul's preaching as an enthusiastic supporter of Judaism before he converted to Christianity (1:13–14; Acts 7:58–8:3). As a Christian, Paul never preached that non-Jews must be circumcised.
- Why am I still being persecuted? If Paul had been promoting a religion based on laws, the devoted Jews would not have been persecuting him everywhere he went. These leaders were angry because Paul taught that people did not need to follow the law of Moses to be saved. They thought this teaching was deeply offensive (compare Romans 9:33; 1 Corinthians 1:23).

## Galatians 5:12

emasculate themselves (literally cut themselves off; compare Philippians 3:2): Paul uses strong words to criticize people who demanded circumcision (cutting off the foreskin from the male sex organ).

1. Paul might refer to pagan priests in Galatia who castrated themselves (removed their testicles) for their gods. Insisting on circumcision for Christians is similar. It involved cutting the flesh to please God through physical actions instead of faith in Christ.
2. Relying on circumcision harmed the false teachers' relationship with God, so they might as well harm themselves physically.
3. In the old covenant, emasculated men could not join the congregation (Deuteronomy 23:1). Similarly, those who depend on circumcision have no place in the new covenant community. Paul likely wished the Judaizers would cut themselves off by leaving the community.

## Galatians 5:13–6.10

Paul explains that justification (being in right relationship with God) comes by faith alone. He then asks, "If we do not follow the law, what guides our behavior?" He answers that the Holy Spirit provides righteousness. The Judaizers (Jewish Christians who believed in following traditional Jewish laws) likely warned that Paul's message of freedom could lead believers to moral failure (5:1). Paul argues that freedom is not an excuse to sin because love guides Christians. We should use our freedom to serve each other with love (see also 2:20; 2 Corinthians 5:14–15).

## Galatians 5:14

The entire law is fulfilled in a single decree: The followers of Jesus fulfill the law by showing love to every neighbor (Leviticus 19:18; see Matthew 7:12; Luke 6:27–36; 10:25–37; John 13:34–35; 15:9–17; Romans 13:8–10).

## Galatians 5:15

The opposite of love is when people hurt and attack each other (see Psalm 35:25; Proverbs 30:14; Jeremiah 8:17). People who lack love are often bitter and fight with one another. They will eventually harm each other. In contrast, love brings life to others (see John 3:16; 15:12–13).

## Galatians 5:16–26

A faith without laws will not cause moral ruin. The Holy Spirit guides people, changing their hearts to follow God's will and not sin (see Jeremiah 31:33; Hebrews 8:10).

## Galatians 5:17

We cannot just choose to follow the law and not sin. There is a struggle between God's Spirit and our sinful nature (see Romans 7:14–25; 1 Peter 2:11; compare Genesis 4:7). The solution is not trying harder to follow the law, but living by God's Spirit. When we are resurrected, we will finally be free from sin (see Romans 8:18–25).

## Galatians 5:18

People guided by the Holy Spirit follow the Spirit's authority, not the law. They answer to the Spirit of God, not the law. Paul did not intend to justify breaking civil laws (see Romans 13:1–7; Titus 3:1; compare 1 Peter 2:13–17). He was talking about how to achieve spiritual righteousness before God.

## Galatians 5:19

- The acts of the flesh are obvious (literally The works of the flesh are): Emphasizing law-keeping and sinful actions comes from trying to live without God's Spirit.
- obvious: All people have a basic sense of right and wrong (see Romans 1:32; 2:14–15; 1 Corinthians 5:1). But some people still choose to do wrong anyway (Romans 1:18–21).
- The list of acts of the flesh starts with sexual immorality. In contrast, the list of Christian virtues starts with love (Galatians 5:22). Various kinds of sexual misconduct were common (see Romans 1:24–27; 1 Corinthians 5:1; 6:15–18; 2 Corinthians 12:21; 2 Peter 3:10, 18). In ancient pagan religions, people engaged in sexual activities as part of their worship of fertility gods and goddesses (see Revelation 2:14, 20).
- When people sin, they become spiritually unclean and cannot have fellowship with God, who is perfectly pure and holy (see Matthew 23:27; Romans 6:19; 2 Corinthians 12:21; Ephesians 5:3; Colossians 3:5; 1 Thessalonians 4:7).

## Galatians 5:19–26

These two lists compare life controlled by sinful desires (5:19–21) with life guided by the Holy Spirit (5:22–26). Living by the Spirit means following a higher moral standard than the law can provide.

## Galatians 5:20

- Idolatry (the worship of false gods) was common in Galatia and often included sorcery ("magic arts," see Acts 19:19; compare 1 Samuel 15:23; Revelation 9:21; 18:23; 21:8; 22:15). It also often included sexual immorality (compare 1 Corinthians 6:9, 15–20).
- Hatred causes people to fight with others, which is the opposite of the Holy Spirit's way of humility and love (Galatians 5:22–23).
- Discord means causing arguments and looking for fights, not peacefully defending what is right (1 Corinthians 3:3; 2 Corinthians 12:20; 1 Timothy 6:4; Titus 3:9). Those who are guided by the Holy Spirit speak what is true with love and try to make peace with others (Galatians 5:22; Ephesians 4:15; 2 Timothy 2:23–26).
- Jealousy (in Greek zēlos, meaning "zeal") can mean a positive "passionate commitment" or a negative "intense desire for others' things" (compare James 3:14–16).
- Rage (violent and uncontrolled anger) is the opposite of self-control (Galatians 5:23; see, for example,

Acts 19:28; 2 Corinthians 12:20; 1 Timothy 3:3; Titus 1:7).
- Rivalries (or selfishness) oppose Christian love (compare Romans 2:8; Philippians 2:3; James 3:14, 16).
- Factions (in Greek haireseis, meaning "heresies, factions, sects") refers to using different beliefs or practices to divide the community (compare 1 Corinthians 11:17–19; 2 Peter 2:1–3).

## Galatians 5:21

- Drunkenness does not belong in a Christian's life (see Luke 21:34; 1 Corinthians 11:20–22; Ephesians 5:18).
- orgies: Religious celebrations for false gods often included wild parties with lots of drinking and sexual sin (compare 1 Peter 4:3).
- and the like: This list shows examples of sinful behaviors (compare Mark 7:20–23; Romans 1:29–31; 1 Corinthians 6:9–10; Ephesians 5:3–5; Colossians 3:5–8; 1 Timothy 1:9–10; 2 Tim 3:2–5; James 3:13–18; Revelation 21:8). People living this way do not follow the Holy Spirit and so they do not show a relationship with God by faith. Such people will not inherit the kingdom of God. They remain slaves to their sinful nature (Galatians 4:8–9, 22–25; compare Romans 6:16–22; 1 Corinthians 6:9–10). They are not under God's rule.

## Galatians 5:22

- Choosing to follow the Holy Spirit leads to a life that pleases God, unlike following sinful desires (5:16; 5:19–21). Human effort and laws cannot achieve this (compare John 15:1–8).
- This list of virtues addresses issues in the Galatian church.
- Love is the greatest Christian virtue and includes all others (1 Corinthians 13:4–7). Only God's Spirit can help us love those who hate us (see Matthew 5:43–48; Luke 6:35–36).
- Joy from the Holy Spirit does not depend on circumstances (see Romans 15:13; 2 Corinthians 6:10; 8:2; 1 Thessalonians 1:6).
- Peace with God brings inner well-being (Romans 5:1; Ephesians 2:15; Philippians 4:6–7; Colossians 1:20). It helps us become peacemakers with others (see Matthew 5:9; Romans 8:6; 12:18; 14:17–19; 2 Corinthians 13:11; Ephesians 4:3; 6:15).
- Patience (or tolerance or long-suffering) helps us endure difficult situations and be patient with others (Ephesians 4:2; 2 Timothy 4:2; James 5:10–11). God is patient with us (Exodus 34:6; Psalms 103:8; Romans 2:4; 9:22; 1 Timothy 1:16; 2 Peter 3:15). God promises to be with those who are patient with others (Isaiah 57:15).
- Kindness means being generous and helping others, showing the same spirit of giving that God shows to us (Romans 2:4; 11:22; Titus 3:4–6).
- Goodness: Compare Romans 15:14; Ephesians 5:9; 2 Thessalonians 1:11.
- Faithfulness (or faith) means being reliable and trustworthy in our relationships, just as God is with us (1 Corinthians 1:9; 10:13; 2 Thessalonians 3:3).

## Galatians 5:23

- Gentleness is the opposite of the bad behaviors in 5:20 and requires strength (see Proverbs 15:1, 4; Matthew 11:28–29; Ephesians 4:2).
- Self-control: The Holy Spirit does not allow immoral behavior but helps people avoid sin (compare Galatians 5:13; Romans 6:14–18; 1 Thessalonians 4:3–7; 1 Peter 2:16; see also Acts 24:25; Titus 1:8).
- Against such things there is no law: Paul explains what is already obvious, that those led by the Holy Spirit do not need laws to guide them.

## Galatians 5:24

- People who trust in Jesus share in his death on the cross through faith (compare 2:19–20; Romans 6). They become new people (Romans 6:1–2; 2 Corinthians 5:17; Colossians 3:5–15). They have left behind their sinful nature and the law (see Galatians 2:19; Romans 7:4–6; 2 Corinthians 5:14; Colossians 3:1–4).
- passions and desires: Refer to 5:19–21.

## Galatians 5:25

Christians do not live by the law but instead let the Holy Spirit guide their lives.

## Galatians 5:26

The Galatian church seemed to struggle with divisions instead of following the guidance of the Holy Spirit (see also study note on 5:20; compare 1 Corinthians 3).

## Galatians 6:1

- Some of the Galatians may have felt proud about how well they followed the law of Moses or how strong their faith was. However, truly godly people do not boast about what they have done. Instead, they humbly help others.
- watch yourself: We can all be tempted to sin (Romans 3:9–20).

## Galatians 6:1–5

Paul explains how to lovingly help other Christians when they make mistakes.

## Galatians 6:1–10

Living by the Spirit (5:13–6:10) leads to doing good deeds (6:1–5) and receiving blessings from the good work we do (6:6–10).

## Galatians 6:2

Helping each other with problems (6:1) follows Christ's command to love one another (5:13–14; see also Leviticus 19:18; Matthew 22:36–40; John 13:34; 15:12; 1 John 3:23).

## Galatians 6:3

People with a proud attitude wrongly think they are too important to help those who are weak (see study note on 6:1).

## Galatians 6:4

We should not think we are better than others. Instead, we should focus on our own actions and make sure we follow Christ in everything (see 1 Corinthians 3:12–15).

## Galatians 6:5

If believers take responsibility for themselves (6:4), they will not treat others as if they are worth less than themselves (6:3).

## Galatians 6:6

Supporting Christian teachers follows the guidance in 5:13 and 6:2 (see also 1 Timothy 5:17–18).

## Galatians 6:6–10

When Christians financially support those who teach God's message (6:6), they gain spiritual benefits.

## Galatians 6:7

- God is not to be mocked: God cannot be deceived by people who only pretend to be spiritual. God knows what is truly in their hearts. Everyone will face the results of their actions.
- Whatever a man sows: see also Job 4:8; Psalms 126:5; Proverbs 22:8; Hosea 8:7; 10:12–15; Luke 19:21–23; 1 Corinthians 3:12–15; 9:11; 2 Corinthians 9:6.

## Galatians 6:8

Living to please the Spirit is only possible with the Spirit's power (3:3; 5:16). People who rely on their own efforts or do whatever they want are in the same situation: They live to satisfy their own sinful desires. These people will face decay and death. Those who live by the Spirit's power and trust in God will gain everlasting life.

## Galatians 6:9

- Let us not grow weary: Avoid letting sinful behavior sneak in or relying on strict rules instead of following the Spirit (5:25).
- for in due time we will reap a harvest: This promise encourages Christians to keep doing good work (see Romans 8:28).
- if we do not give up: God's promises to believers require them to keep their faith strong (see also Luke 18:1; 2 Corinthians 4:1).

## Galatians 6:10

- Therefore: This statement forms an inclusio that marks the beginning and end of this section (5:13–6:10), like two bookends that hold it together by repeating the theme from 5:13: Freedom in the Spirit urges us to do good to others with love.
- Doing good to those in the faith community shows God's faithfulness to his children. This action directly shows how God meets all their needs.

## Galatians 6:11–18

Paul picked up the writing tool from his amanuensis (secretary) and wrote a postscript himself. He did this to prove the letter was truly his and to make a final appeal.

## Galatians 6:12–13

Despite their theological arguments, the false teachers were self-serving. They wanted approval from non-Christian Jews and cared more about their reputation than honoring God.

## Galatians 6:14

- Unlike the false teachers mentioned in 6:12–13, Paul wanted to increase God's glory. He did not want to increase his own reputation. Boasting about following the law would take away from recognizing the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ.
- In the Greco-Roman world, the cross seemed foolish to non-believers (5:11; 1 Corinthians 1:23; compare John 6:53–61). But it is the foundation of a Christian's faith and hope (1 Corinthians 1:17–18; 15:3; Philippians 2:8–11; Colossians 1:20–22; 2:14–15).

## Galatians 6:15

The Galatians misunderstood the good news about Jesus. A new creation comes through Jesus Christ by the Holy Spirit, not by human effort (compare 2 Corinthians 5:16–17).

## Galatians 6:16

- This rule is trusting Jesus for salvation (6:14–15).
- even to the Israel of God: The Greek word kai is usually translated as "and." It can also mean "even." If it means "and," then the Israel of God is a different group from all who walk by this rule. If it means "even," then they are the same group.

The Jewish people still have a special identity before God (Romans 9:1–5; 10:1–4; 11:1–32). Gentiles (non-Jewish people) who believe have been included, and Jews who do not believe have been removed from spiritual Israel (Romans 11:17–24; compare Philippians 3:2–3; Colossians 2:11–12). Paul sees all Christians as the true Israel (see Romans 2:28–29; 9:6–8; compare Galatians 4:21–31).

The phrase the Israel of God is not found elsewhere in the New Testament or other writings. Perhaps false teachers promised this identity to Gentiles who accepted circumcision. If so, Paul shows why their argument was wrong: The non-Jewish Christians in Galatia did not need circumcision, as they were already God's Israel—his true people—through faith in Christ.

## Galatians 6:17

- let no one cause me trouble: No one has the right to criticize Paul or his message because he is a proven servant of Jesus.
- Paul's scars (in Greek stigmata) likely came from the severe persecution he experienced as a servant of Jesus (see Acts 14:19; 2 Corinthians 6:4–10; 11:21–33). Unlike the physical mark of circumcision that false teachers in Galatia wanted to force on non-Jewish Christians, Paul's scars from suffering showed he was truly the servant of Jesus (compare Exodus 21:6).

## Galatians 6:18

Paul prayed at the end of this letter just as he did at the start (1:3–4). The Galatians needed the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ to be with their spirit more than they needed the law.